

years to ethnomusicological research until a meeting with another alluring violinist Jelly d'Arányi (see box) drew him back to composition. In 1923, he and Márta were divorced; only two months later he proposed to one of his piano students, Ditta Pasztory, who was 19 to his 42, and married her 10 days afterward. The following year, their son Péter was born.

The interwar years saw an upswing in Bartók's renown. He established himself on the international scene with such works as his first two piano concertos, the *Cantata Profana* (1930), *Music for Strings, Percussion, and Celesta* (1936) and the *Sonata for Two Pianos and Percussion* (1937). He also toured Europe, America, and the Soviet Union as a pianist. However, as right-wing politics began to take hold in Hungary, Bartók's loathing of fascist ideology put him at risk of state retribution: in Germany, his ballet *The Miraculous Mandarin* (written in 1918–1919) was banned for its sexually explicit content.

Bartók spent a last idyllic summer in Switzerland in 1939, working on his sixth and final string quartet and the *Divertimento* for string orchestra, which had been commissioned by the philanthropist Paul Sacher. The following year, the Bartóks left Hungary and emigrated to the US.

There, holding an modest post as a “research assistant” at Columbia University, Bartók faced an uphill struggle to gain commissions and provide for his family. His health, too, was suffering. Less than two years after they arrived, he began to develop symptoms of a serious illness that turned out to be leukemia.